plans.' Observing events, a West Berlin spokesmen called it a 'most dangerous manifestation of Soviet mass influence on German soil'.9

Despite the good start, behind the scenes, the event was swamped by leadership chaos. Instead of attending discussion seminars and rallies, many visitors slipped over to West Berlin, strolled along the Kurfürstendamm, took rides on double-decker buses, and enjoyed the famous Zoologischer Garten. Over the next few days, hundreds of young East Germans decided to defy orders and took similar jaunts. Through it all, West Berlin's mayor, Ernst Reuter, exploited the chaos by arranging his own 'capitalist' events and offering free drinks and snacks to the young tourists. Furious, Honecker mustered FDJ members to march into the Western sectors, flags flying, singing communist songs. The effort, however, turned into a fiasco when West Berlin police officers – untrained in patience or tolerance – pushed a column of 3,000 FDJers back from the sector boundary at Schlesische Brücke, arresting sixty-two. There were scattered incidents of violence at Neukölln, where two cordons of FRG policemen assembled at either end of the high street, trapping 4,000 FDJ marchers between them, and after ten minutes of scuffles, cleared the streets by force. Movements were also underway in Wedding, where police blasted water cannons to end a protest.

All of this was captured on film by SFB, the West German TV, and broadcast repeatedly on both Berlin and European television. Later that afternoon, Honecker arrived at the Schlesische Brücke to condemn the 'brutal actions' of the West Berlin police, which, he barked had 'unmasked itself and openly expressed what it understood freedom to be'.10

Ignoring taunts from West Germans, he made fantastic claims that 'numerous agents' had been arrested in East Berlin: 'We have clamped down on quite a number of agents including several who tried to poison the food of festival participants with certain tablets.'11 As this was happening, Margo Feist – who was equally quick on her feet – was at Arkonaplatz in the Mitte district, perched on a garden wall protesting the 'hypocrisy of the West Berlin administration,' which, she screamed, 'attempted to lure the youngsters and then beat them down with truncheons'.12

Honecker's sanitised account, completely lacking in any real sense of proportion, stated that 'when 100,000 young peace fighters demonstrated in